



NATIONAL HIGH SCHOOL
ETHICS BOWL

REGIONAL CASE SET

2026-2027

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* POSSIBLE DIVISIONAL PLAYOFFS CASE (6)

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FROM THE EDITORIAL BOARD

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

The cases in this set were compiled for affiliated Regional Competitions during the 2026-2027 National High School Ethics Bowl season. Authored by a diverse group of community members, cases have been edited for content, clarity, and pedagogical focus by an Editorial Board composed of NHSEB's Executive Committee and Case Advisory Committee. More information on NHSEB personnel is available at nhseb.org/people.

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EDITORIAL NOTE: DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

The discussion questions provided by the Editorial Board in this set are designed to identify and get students thinking about the various moral and political questions, significant issues, and potential angles of consideration involved in each case. Provided discussion questions do not (and are not designed to) exhaust the range of possible questions or considerations on a given topic. Discussion questions *will not* be used for officially-sanctioned NHSEB Regional Competitions or Divisional Playoffs. The Moderator Questions asked at each NHSEB-affiliated event will remain confidential until they are revealed in-match to preserve competitive fairness. For more information about discussion questions and competition procedures, please review NHSEB's 2026-2027 [Rules Manual](#).

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Cases designed for use in the National High School Ethics Bowl are often directly based on or otherwise inspired by real-world events, debates, etc. Throughout this case set, citations and references are included to provide further context on these events and issues where appropriate. Source materials cited in this document will only be identified once per case, though may be referenced more than once within a given case.

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1: Freedom Hill and Higher Ground

Princeville, North Carolina, sits along the Tar River in Edgecombe County. Founded after the Civil War by formerly enslaved people and originally known as Freedom Hill, Princeville is widely recognized as the oldest town incorporated by Black Americans in the United States. Its history is not incidental to its location: the town became a place where Black residents could own land, govern themselves, build churches and schools, and sustain a community after Emancipation.

Princeville is also highly vulnerable to flooding. It was devastated by Hurricane Floyd in 1999 and flooded again after Hurricane Matthew in 2016. Residents and officials continue to face the same question: should Princeville rebuild where it is, or should residents move to higher ground?

Imagine that if, after another serious flood, state and federal officials offered Princeville a major recovery package that would fund new homes, roads, and public buildings on higher ground nearby. Residents who moved would receive financial assistance, and the historic center of Princeville would be preserved as a cultural and memorial district rather than a residential neighborhood. Officials advocate for this kind of solution by arguing that climate change and repeated flooding make it irresponsible to spend public money rebuilding homes in areas likely to flood again. Additionally, they stress that emergency workers should not be asked to repeatedly risk their lives rescuing residents from preventable danger.

Many residents disagree. Some say that moving Princeville, even nearby, would amount to losing Princeville. For them, the land is not merely a replaceable location. It is the physical site of ancestors' struggle, survival, worship, burial, and political self-rule. One resident says, "If our ancestors stayed here when they had almost nothing, who are we to leave just because the government now thinks our home is inconvenient?" Others worry that relocation would make it easier for outsiders to turn a living town into a museum- honoring Black history only after displacing the Black community that preserved it.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Do governments, communities, and families have any moral duty to move people away from danger, even when relocation threatens tradition, memory, and attachment?
2. If more and more communities are displaced by environmental factors¹, how might challenges to the sustainability of relocation affect how we think about this case?
3. When resources are limited how should funding distributions be ethically allocated to communities affected by natural disasters?

¹ <https://magazine.columbia.edu/article/americas-great-climate-migration-has-begun-heres-what-you-need-know>

2: Biting Back

Maria and Dani have been best friends since middle school. They tell each other almost everything, and most of their classmates think of them as inseparable. However, this year their friendship has become strained as Dani has started spending more time with another group of friends, and Maria increasingly feels left out. One afternoon, Maria invites Dani to work on a history project together after school. Dani declines, saying she has other things to do. Later that evening, Maria opens social media and sees photos of Dani spending time with several other classmates working on the same project together. Maria feels excluded and hurt, in addition to feeling angry because Dani wasn't honest about her plans.

When Maria gets home, she tells her father everything. She explains why she feels betrayed and asks for advice about whether she should confront Dani or let the friendship fade. Talking through the situation helps Maria feel better, and the next day, Maria tells two mutual friends about the situation. They sympathize with her and share their own frustrations with Dani. One mentions that Dani often cancels plans at the last minute. The other recalls a time Dani forgot someone's birthday. None of what they say is false, but Dani isn't present to explain herself or defend her actions.

Over the next week, the story spreads through several friend groups. Some students begin viewing Dani differently, not because of anything she has recently done, but because so many small criticisms have accumulated through conversations she never knew were happening. Maria feels guilty. She never intended to damage Dani's reputation, she only wanted support when she was feeling hurt.

Maria's older brother thinks she did nothing wrong. People naturally seek advice from parents and trusted friends, especially when they are confused or upset. Sometimes discussing another person's actions is the only practical way to understand what happened or decide how to respond.

Maria's grandmother disagrees. She tells Maria that conversations about people who are absent have a tendency to grow beyond their original purpose. What begins as asking for advice can slowly become criticism and an opportunity to bond over someone else's shortcomings. Even when everything being said is true, another person's reputation can be harmed without them ever having the chance to speak for themselves.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. If private conversations about others carry the risk of becoming gossip, do we have a moral obligation to actively avoid having them?
2. How should we prioritize the wishes of others against our own needs? When there is a conflict between a need to express legitimate frustration and another person's desire to preserve their reputation, what considerations should determine what is permissible?

3: The Man Who Never Was

In April 1943, at the height of World War II, British intelligence officers Ewen Montagu and Charles Cholmondeley orchestrated an unconventional deception plan on Nazi Germany. Code-named Operation Mincemeat, they dressed a corpse as a fictitious Royal Marines officer, “Major William Martin,” planting false invasion documents on him, and then floating the body off the coast of Spain into Nazi spies’ hands. The misinformation successfully convinced Hitler to redirect numerous German troops from an actual Allied invasion target, allowing for an expedited invasion with an estimated 40,000 fewer Allied casualties.¹

“Major Martin” was, in reality, a recently deceased thirty-four-year-old Welsh homeless man named Glyndwr Michael, who had died in London after ingesting rat poison, likely by suicide. With both parents deceased, Michael had no known close relatives, meaning no one remained to grant consent or object to the government’s use of his remains. In fact, the coroner, Bentley Purchase, falsified death records in order to facilitate the operation.

Defenders of the operation point to its extraordinarily positive consequences. Since Michael was already dead, and his body would have otherwise been buried in an unmarked pauper’s grave, the loss of his dignity can be seen as minimal when compared to the tens of thousands of lives saved. Furthermore, the operation gave his death a significance it never would have had otherwise. They further posit that during wartime, the ordinary moral calculus may shift; perhaps exceptions should be made to typical moral laws under dire circumstances.

Others, however, are troubled since Michael never consented to having his body used as a means to the invasion’s successful end, nor did anyone close to him consent on his behalf. The deliberate falsification of his death records compounds the concerns. Critics argue that, regardless of the outcome, using a person’s body without consent fundamentally violates their autonomy, reducing them from a human to a mere instrument.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is it ever morally permissible to use a deceased person’s body without their consent for the benefit of others?
2. Does the magnitude of the good achieved change the moral calculus of using someone’s body without consent?
3. Is there a morally relevant distinction between using a body for military deception and using organs for transplantation?

¹ <https://army.togetherweserved.com/dispatches-articles/72/627/Operation+Mincemeat+-+A+Turning+Point+in+WWII>

4: A Generational Deal

For many older American homeowners, the dream of growing old in their home has become more difficult.. Although their mortgage may have been paid off years ago, rapidly increasing home values have also increased property taxes and for retirees living primarily on Social Security or fixed pensions, these rising taxes can become difficult to afford, even though they have no intention of selling their homes.

Several states already provide some form of property tax relief for seniors. Texas, Illinois, New Jersey, and Arkansas, among others, allow assessment freezes or similar protections for qualifying older homeowners, while many additional states offer exemptions, credits, or deferral programs that reduce property taxes for seniors living on fixed incomes. These programs seek to reduce the burden on seniors and avoid forcing them to return to the workforce just to afford their homes. Many older Americans believe these policies simply honor an implicit agreement between generations. Throughout their working lives they paid taxes that funded public programs for the generation before them. Now, after decades of contributing to society, some feel that society has an obligation to ensure they can age with dignity and remain in the communities they helped build.

Others worry that this way of thinking overlooks the challenges facing younger generations. Home prices have risen dramatically in many cities while wages have not kept pace, making homeownership increasingly difficult for first-time buyers. Economists note that when homeowners face fewer financial incentives to sell, fewer homes may enter the housing market, reducing supply and pushing prices even higher. Critics also worry that broad property tax freezes could benefit wealthy retirees who own valuable homes or even multiple properties. If someone can continue renting out investment property while paying frozen property taxes, younger taxpayers may end up subsidizing wealth accumulation rather than financial need. Moreover, today's young adults are paying into Social Security and Medicare while also facing record housing costs, rising college debt, and uncertainty about whether those same programs will remain financially secure when they retire. They question whether public policy should continue expanding benefits tied simply to age instead of directing resources toward people with the greatest financial need regardless of generation.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What factors should matter most when considering who should receive tax breaks?
2. What, if anything, do you think different age cohorts owe one another?
3. When aid is given, who should be most responsible for taking on the financial burden?

5: Papal Authority

On May 25, 2026, the Vatican published the first encyclical of Pope Leo XIV, titled *Magnifica Humanitas* (“Magnificent Humanity”), subtitled “On Safeguarding the Human Person in the Time of Artificial Intelligence,” which argues that technology is neither inherently evil nor ever truly neutral, since it takes on the aims of those who design, fund, and deploy it.¹ The Pope called for AI to be directed toward the common good and, in a striking phrase, said the technology “must” be “disarmed.”² He warned that humanity faces a choice between building “a new Tower of Babel” and building a world fit for human dignity.

The timing was deliberate. Leo signed the document on the 135th anniversary of *Rerum Novarum*, the 1891 encyclical in which Pope Leo XIII addressed the upheavals of the Industrial Revolution and helped launch modern Catholic social teaching.³ The new pope casts AI as a comparable turning point for human dignity, justice, and labor.

The encyclical drew wide attention well beyond the Church, with commentators across the political and technological spectrum quoting it approvingly. That reach is precisely what makes the case interesting. When a religious leader weighs in on a global technological question, what authority, if any, does that intervention carry in a debate that is largely secular and pluralistic?

One view welcomes such voices. Questions about AI, about human dignity, work, truth, and what kind of beings we want to remain, are moral and even spiritual, not merely technical. Religious traditions have spent centuries thinking about human nature and the common good, and a leader who speaks for over a billion people can convene attention and conscience in ways that engineers and regulators cannot. On this view, keeping moral and religious reasoning out of public technology debates impoverishes them.

A competing view is wary. In a diverse society, many do not share the Pope's faith, and grounding technology policy in the teaching of one religious tradition can feel like an imposition. Skeptics question whether moral authority translates into competence on the technical and economic realities of AI, and whether sweeping calls to “disarm” the technology offer real guidance.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Does moral or spiritual authority give someone standing to weigh in on technical and economic questions like AI governance, or are these genuinely separate kinds of expertise that shouldn't be expected to overlap?
2. Does it matter whether AI tools were used to help draft a document warning about the dangers of AI? Would that fact, if true, undermine the document's authority, or is the content of the argument independent of how it was produced?
3. Who should have the authority to ask (and answer) moral questions about the collective future of our species?

¹ [Encyclical Letter of His Holiness Leo XIV, Magnifica Humanitas](#)

² [Pope Leo Warns Artificial Intelligence Could Be “New Tower Of Babel”](#)

³ [Pope Leo's 'Magnifica humanitas': AI must serve humanity not concentrate power](#)

6: For The Love Of Timmy

In early 2026 Timmy, a young adult humpback whale, made her way into the Baltic Sea where she was spotted swimming especially close to the German coastline. Humpback whales rarely enter the Baltic because its shallow, low-salinity waters make it difficult for them to navigate and find food. Over several weeks, Timmy repeatedly became stranded on sandbanks, was entangled in fishing nets, and grew visibly weaker. Millions of people followed the story through livestreams and news coverage, hoping that someone could save her.

From the beginning, experts disagreed about what should be done. Some marine biologists argued that rescue attempts were unlikely to succeed and would only increase Timmy's suffering. They believed the whale had already been weakened by weeks in unsuitable water and that repeatedly moving or handling such a large animal would cause additional stress. Some even suggested that euthanasia might ultimately be the most humane option if her condition continued to deteriorate.

Others, however, argued that Timmy was still fighting to survive and deserved every reasonable chance to return to the open ocean. They believed that giving up too early would ignore humanity's responsibility to help an animal whose predicament may have been influenced by human activity, including fishing gear, heavy shipping traffic, and changing marine environments.

After weeks of debate, private donors funded an ambitious rescue unlike any previously attempted. Volunteers dug a channel through the sand, guided Timmy onto a specially prepared barge, and transported her hundreds of kilometers to the North Sea before releasing her there. The rescue was celebrated internationally as a triumph of cooperation, engineering, and compassion.

The celebration did not last long. Timmy's body was discovered a few days later near Denmark. Scientists concluded that she had likely died shortly after being released. Some viewed the outcome as tragic evidence that experts who had opposed the rescue had been correct all along. Others argued that although the rescue failed, attempting to save a suffering animal was still the morally right decision. They believed that success cannot always be measured by the outcome alone, since rescuers acted out of compassion under conditions of uncertainty. Others still pointed out that Timmy's rescue reportedly cost around €1.5 million. The resource cost of the effort led some conservationists to ask whether those resources could have produced greater benefits through habitat restoration or broader marine conservation efforts.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. How should we determine what we owe to wildlife that we believe to be suffering?
2. What are our moral obligations when we are in some way directly, or as a species, responsible for hardship in nature?
3. How ought we judge how to most ethically use donated funds? When there are tensions between the wishes of a donor and the group who has received funding, how should we decide what to do with the money?

7: A Matter Of Life And Data

When 78-year-old Margaret suffers a severe stroke, she is left unconscious and unable to communicate. Doctors believe she may recover enough to survive for years with aggressive treatment, but they need to make difficult decisions immediately. Margaret never completed an advance directive, and while she appointed her son David as her medical decision-maker years ago, the document provides little guidance about the kinds of treatments she would want. David is overwhelmed. He remembers his mother saying she “never wanted to be kept alive by machines,” but also recalls her agreeing to undergo an invasive heart surgery several years earlier because she wanted “every chance” to see her grandchildren grow up.

At Margaret's hospital, physicians are piloting a new artificial intelligence system designed to help in exactly these situations. Rather than making decisions itself, the AI generates a report estimating what treatment the patient would likely prefer. The program analyzes years of information—including medical records, previous treatment choices, recorded conversations with physicians, and, with permission, digital information such as emails or journals—to build what researchers describe as a personalized model of the patient's values. Some researchers have even suggested that future systems might use information from social media or other digital footprints to improve these predictions.

The medical team explains that the AI would not replace David's authority. Instead, it would serve as another source of evidence, similar to consulting multiple family members or reviewing an advance directive. They argue that the AI might notice patterns no human could identify. If Margaret consistently chose quality of life over longevity in previous medical decisions, or repeatedly expressed similar values over many years, perhaps the AI could recognize those themes more reliably than a distraught family member. They also point out that the technology might reduce the enormous emotional burden placed on surrogates by giving them additional confidence that they are honoring their loved one's wishes.

David is uneasy. He worries that no computer, regardless of how sophisticated it becomes, could truly understand who his mother is. People's values often change over time. The opinions Margaret expressed in her fifties may not reflect what she believed in her late seventies after becoming a grandmother, losing close friends, and living with chronic illness. Even if the AI correctly predicts what someone probably would have chosen, David wonders whether probabilities are enough when the stakes are life and death. He also questions whether he is comfortable with software analyzing years of intensely personal data to infer preferences Margaret never explicitly shared.

Others raise a different concern. If an AI prediction disagrees with a surrogate's judgment, whose voice should matter more? Families are not always accurate, but they often possess knowledge that cannot easily be captured in data: private conversations, subtle changes in personality, or deeply held values that were never written down. At the same time, surrogates can be influenced by guilt, wishful thinking, or their own beliefs about what should happen. Perhaps an AI trained on a person's lifetime of choices could, in some circumstances, better represent that person's autonomy than even their closest relatives.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. How much weight should families give to AI recommendations compared to the recommendations of other “non-family” humans, when making medical decisions?
2. If a patient expressed a preference regarding the use of this technology that family members disagreed with, what moral and practical considerations should determine how they proceed?

8: Our Best Baby

Maya and Sunil want to have children, but Maya is concerned about their family genetic history. One of her nephews was born deaf, and Sunil's father died from type-1 diabetes at age 52. So, Maya does some research on-line and finds information about a company called Nucleus Genomics.¹ "Have your best baby," declares the attractive Nucleus website. "The modern way ... driven by science, guided by love." Using DNA swabs from the cheek of each parent, the company employs a patented model to construct the genetic profile of their potential offspring. Then, using in vitro fertilization methods that have been safely employed by millions of people worldwide, they are able to screen embryos for any abnormalities, ensuring a healthy baby. The website explains that "9 in 10 parents are carriers for a genetic condition," "2.8 million children in the US have a genetic condition," and "2 in 3 couples are likely to have children at higher risk for at least one common disease."²

Maya is relieved to know there is a way to avoid genetic abnormalities in her potential children. However, she is disturbed to learn that Nucleus also offers parents the option to select for desirable traits like height, athleticism and intelligence. "It seems wrong to choose the features of your child as if it were a new car," she tells Sunil. "Isn't it enough to have a healthy baby?"

Sunil understands Maya's concern, but as he studies more about the process, he finds himself agreeing with the Nucleus perspective. "Why shouldn't we select the best attributes for our child if it is within our power to do so? After all, aren't parents supposed to seek the best for their children?"

Maya feels that they should only use Nucleus to screen out what's dangerous, not to artificially select traits they perceive as good or advantageous. Bringing new life into existence is a mystery and a gift, and she does not want to lose the attitude of awe and gratitude that she hopes to feel towards her future child.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is there a moral difference between screening out harmful traits like diabetes and selecting for traits perceived as desirable like height, intelligence, and athleticism?
2. Is Maya justified in her concern that genetic screening and IVF techniques may diminish the value of life by turning the mystery of procreation into a product humans control?
3. What social and economic concerns may be attached to genetic screening techniques that can cost hundreds of thousands of dollars per child?
4. Should the company include the cost of a counselor (of the family's choosing) or of genetic testing so that parents can receive objective guidance?

¹ <https://mynucleus.com/>

² <https://mynucleus.com/preview>

9: United We School

Across the rural United States, a small but growing number of charter schools have emerged that serve almost entirely one ethnic or cultural community. Some were founded by Indigenous nations seeking to revive languages nearly lost to a century of federal boarding school policy, which forcibly separated Native children from their families in order to erase their cultures. Others were founded by immigrant or religious communities in isolated farming towns, where families wanted a school that reflected their traditions, language, and values. No law assigns students to these schools by race or ethnicity. Families choose them freely, year after year, often because they offer a sense of belonging that a more diverse local school did not. And yet, in classroom after classroom, the result is a student population that looks remarkably homogeneous.

On paper, these rural charter schools are the opposite of the segregation that federal civil rights law was written to prevent. They are unforced and locally chosen, often led by the very communities they serve, and frequently built around the goals of cultural survival and belonging. But the outcome, a school where nearly every student shares one background, is difficult to distinguish, on its face, from segregation itself.

Supporters of these schools often argue that cultural concentration serves values too easily dismissed by a one-size-fits-all approach to integration. For communities whose languages and traditions were nearly erased by past government policy, a school built around that identity can function as an act of repair rather than exclusion, offering students a place to study their own history and language in depth. These schools are also frequently framed as protective: many were established after students reported bullying, isolation, or a persistent sense of not belonging at more diverse schools. Supporters point out that voluntary association around a shared identity is common and rarely controversial in other contexts, such as language-immersion schools, faith-based schools, or schools for the Deaf, and they ask why a rural school built around an ethnic or cultural identity should be treated any differently.

Critics counter that the voluntariness of these schools may be less complete than it first appears. If students are only "choosing" a homogeneous school because the alternative treated them poorly, the choice may reflect a failure of the broader system rather than a genuinely free preference. Critics also point to research suggesting that charter schools nationwide tend to be more racially isolated than the traditional public schools around them, a trend that has drawn civil rights scrutiny for over a decade regardless of the intentions of any individual school. Beyond the fairness concerns, some worry about what students may lose developmentally: if schools are partly responsible for preparing children for a diverse civic and professional life, a K-12 education spent almost entirely within one culture might leave students less equipped to navigate a world that will rarely be so homogeneous.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Are these schools a legitimate exercise of a community's right to shape its own education, or an updated version of an old and troubling pattern, regardless of the good intentions behind it?
2. How much say should legislative bodies have in how communities organize around education? Does the "tax-funded" nature of public charter schools matter?

10: Elucktoral college

"Sortition" is an ancient practice in which political leaders are selected randomly, by lottery, rather than through elections. In ancient Athens, most public officials were chosen this way, using a stone device that randomly drew citizens' names for office. Some modern political theorists want to revive the idea. One proposal imagines replacing an elected legislature with a network of committees, each filled by randomly selected citizens and each responsible for a single policy area, like the environment or taxation.

When Mia and Theo learned about the idea in class, Mia was immediately drawn to the fairness of it. Under the current system, she pointed out, winning an election takes money, name recognition, and the ability to perform well in public, none of which have much to do with whether someone would actually govern wisely. A lottery, by contrast, gives every citizen the exact same chance of holding office, regardless of wealth or charisma. To Mia, that felt like a truer form of equal representation than voting, since an election only guarantees an equal chance to choose a leader, not an equal chance to become one.

Theo agreed that political campaigning has real problems, but he wasn't ready to give up on voting itself. For him, elections are how citizens consent to being governed. When people cast a ballot for someone, they're authorizing that person to act on their behalf, and those same voters retain the power to remove a leader later if they govern badly. Under a lottery system, Theo asked, what happens if the person selected turns out to be dishonest or bad at the job? To him, the act of voting has value as an expression of political will, even if the available candidates aren't representative of the total population.

Mia points out that plenty of elected officials spend their time courting donors and chasing short-term popularity instead of focusing on good policy, precisely because their jobs depend on winning the next election. A randomly selected official, serving a single term with nothing left to campaign for, might actually be freer to act on the public's behalf. She compared it to jury duty: nobody runs a campaign to become a juror, yet we trust ordinary citizens, chosen at random, to make serious and consequential decisions all the time.

That comparison didn't fully satisfy Theo. Serving on a jury, he noted, is temporary and narrow, deciding a single case with guidance from judges and lawyers. Governing a city or a country is a much bigger, more open-ended responsibility, one that might call for experience, judgment, or motivation that not everyone happens to have. He worried that choosing leaders at random risks handing serious decisions to people who never sought the job and might not want it or be qualified to handle it, while overlooking those who have spent years preparing to serve.

Mia wasn't sure that wanting the job was actually a good qualification, since plenty of people who eagerly seek power do so for the wrong reasons. Still, she admitted she wasn't certain that the actions of a randomly selected government would feel legitimate to everyone, even if they brought about good consequences.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is it a problem for democracy that those who can (and do) run for office are not a representative sample of the population, even in places that limit the influence of money on campaigning?
2. Is the act of voting itself valuable even when your preferred candidate loses?
3. Is it reasonable to entrust a jury of random citizens to determine the fate of someone accused of a crime?

11: Not In My Cloud

In July 2026, New York became the first state to institute a one-year construction ban on data centers using 50 megawatts of power or more.¹ New York isn't an outlier. From Ohio to Alabama to Oklahoma, local resistance to the construction of data centers has pushed legislators to act. In fact, there have been nearly 100 proposed moratoriums from both Democrats and Republicans at various levels of government, ranging from short-term pauses to permanent bans.²

A data center is a building filled with computing infrastructure, including systems and servers that process, move, and store a massive amount of information. These networks support services like cloud storage, apps, websites, and of course, AI. As companies race to develop AI, there has been a major push to build more of these facilities throughout the country to meet the massive increase in computing demand.

Critics of data centers point to harm to individuals and the environment. A large data center can use as much electricity as a small city.³ In states with many data centers, like Virginia, electricity prices have increased by up to 267% over the last five years as data centers accounted for nearly 40% of all electricity used in the state.⁴ AI data centers consume up to 5 million gallons of water daily and can release chemical, noise, and light pollutants.⁵

Proponents of data centers point out that they generate revenue via taxes and create job opportunities. Virginia generated about \$31 billion in economic output from data center operations in 2023 alone, and the industry supported over 78,000 jobs.⁶ Many note that advances in AI are leading to breakthroughs in many fields, and data centers are necessary to fuel this innovation.

Increasing demand for AI and cloud computing means data centers will ultimately need to be built somewhere. Notably, nearly half of existing data centers are located in areas with social vulnerability indicators such as poverty and low education levels.⁷

The public tide against data centers is growing: in August 2025, 4 out of 10 respondents in a Heatmap News poll said they'd oppose a data center in their area. By May 2026, 7 in 10 respondents said they would oppose.⁸ Governments around the nation are trying to decide how to best handle both the demand for computing power and local opposition to data center construction..

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Should residents have a right to refuse infrastructure if that infrastructure benefits other nearby communities, or even the nation as a whole, more than the affected community itself?
2. How should a government balance the need to increase economic growth with potential harm to some of their community members?
3. Is there a morally relevant difference between data centers and other infrastructure projects that locals may not want nearby, like power plants, highways, or landfills?

¹ Reuters, "New York becomes the first state to impose a data center moratorium" (<https://www.reuters.com/world/new-york-becomes-first-state-impose-data-center-moratorium-2026-07-14/>)

² New York Times, "The Movement to Stop Data Centers" (<https://www.nytimes.com/2026/06/09/climate/data-center-bans.html>)

³ Consumer Reports, "AI Data Centers: Big Tech' Impact on Electric Bills, Water, and More" (<https://www.consumerreports.org/data-centers/ai-data-centers-impact-on-electric-bills-water-and-more-a1040338678/>)

⁴ Ibid

⁵ World Resources Institute, "From Energy Use to Air Quality, the Many Ways Data Centers Affect US Communities" (<https://www.wri.org/insights/us-data-center-growth-impacts>)

⁶ Northern Virginia Technology Council, "Virginia Data Centers Supported 78, 140 Jobs and \$31.4 Billion Economic Output in 2023" (<https://www.nvtc.org/press-releases/virginia-data-centers-supported-78140-jobs-and-31-4-billion-in-economic-output-in-2023/>)

⁷ World Resources Institute, "From Energy Use to Air Quality, the Many Ways Data Centers Affect US Communities"

⁸ New York Times, "The Movement to Stop Data Centers"



12: A Sacred Divide

Ailey and Tadros have been together for eight years and married for five. Their relationship has always been affectionate, supportive, and stable.

Both Tadros and Ailey grew up in extremely religious households. While Tadros found a deep connection with the church, Ailey never did. In fact, Ailey only identified as religious because of the constant church presence in her family's life and feeling pressure from her parents.

As an adult, Ailey began to feel increasingly frustrated with the church and the family pressure to take on an identity she never chose for herself. After years of reflection, but after she and Tadros had married, Ailey eventually determined she did not believe in God and decided to leave the church. The two respect each other's religious beliefs and have come to terms with their differences.

Both Tadros and Ailey have always known that they want children. However, when they recently began to talk about starting a family, the conversations became tense. Tadros wants to raise their children in the church. He feels strongly about the benefits of building an early connection to religion and that parents must guide their children on important questions of morality and faith. Ailey, on the other hand, does not want to subject her own children to the experience she had of being told what to believe. It isn't that Ailey is against her children joining the church, it is that she doesn't want their life structured around it before they can make a choice. She doesn't want her child to feel trapped, as she felt for years that she could not leave the church because it was the foundation of her early and important relationships.

While Tadros is aware of these potential problems, he is convinced that the risks of *not* raising their children in the church are much higher: he believes in eternal damnation, and avoiding that fate is far more important than potential resentment or fractured relationships. Ailey thinks it is unfair for him to appeal to religious concepts like eternity when weighing the pros and cons of parenting choices, since eternal salvation and damnation are supposed to outweigh all earthly concerns by definition, and they don't agree on the religious claims to begin with.

It has been a week since Ailey and Tadros argued, and neither is excited to bring up the topic again, but they both feel it is an issue they must work through if their relationship is going to endure.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. How should prospective parents who hold different views about what is most valuable work through their disagreements?
2. How should the possibility of infinitely good or infinitely bad outcomes influence our deliberations about what to do and what to believe?
3. To what extent should parents try to impart their own values to their children?

13: A Grade By Any Other Name

Jamal and Ruby are working on a group project when their history teacher announces a small experiment: for the next unit, students may choose to receive detailed written feedback on their essays instead of letter grades, while those who don't want to participate will receive letter grades as usual. The experiment is optional and temporary, but if it goes well their teacher might experiment further with alternatives to traditional grading. Jamal signs up immediately. Ruby decides to stay in the graded section. Over lunch, they end up discussing their choices.

Jamal has never liked how much he thinks about grades instead of the material itself. He tells Ruby that whenever he receives an assignment, his first question becomes "What does the teacher want?" rather than "What do I actually think?" He picks safer topics for essays because a bold argument risks a lower score, and he has caught himself skimming the parts of a reading that won't be tested, even when he thinks they are interesting. To Jamal, this isn't a personal failing so much as what grades train one to do: they turn learning into a transaction, where the point of writing an essay becomes earning an A rather than understanding the subject. He thinks a class without grades might let him actually enjoy learning again, instead of constantly performing for a number.

Ruby sees it differently. She works hard in every class, and she wants that effort to be recognized in a way that means something outside the classroom. Without grades, she asks, how would colleges or employers know who actually mastered the material and who coasted? She also points out that grades give her useful information about herself. A C on a rough draft tells her clearly that something isn't working yet, in a way that vague comments like "this section could use improvement" might not. Ruby worries that removing grades doesn't remove the underlying pressure to succeed. It just removes the clearest, most honest signal of how she's doing, and replaces it with guesswork. Jamal pushes back. If the goal of school is to learn, he argues, then a system based on ranking students for the benefit of people outside of the school works against that goal, even while it looks fair on paper.

Ruby points out that not every incentive is bad just because it is indirect. Athletes train harder not only because they want to play better but also because they want an athletic scholarship. Employees work harder knowing a raise is possible. She doesn't see why learning should be the one area of life where people must be moved by purely intrinsic motivations. Some structure and stakes, she argues, actually push people to do their best work and grades might be more motivating than curiosity alone.

Jamal isn't so sure the comparison holds. A race has a finish line everyone can see and agree on. Learning, he says, doesn't really work like that, since real understanding often looks messy, slow, and hard to capture in a single letter grade. He wonders whether the desire for a clean, comparable number says more about what administrators and politicians want from school than what's actually good for the students in the classroom.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Does introducing a numerical metric for measuring success undermine activities that we typically think are valuable for their own sakes like learning, art, or living a healthy lifestyle?
2. How should schools and universities balance the goal of educating students with the goal of supplying credentials that are useful for employers and other organizations?

14: Face Off

During the 2023 Hollywood labor disputes, some background actors reported that studios had scanned their faces and bodies and claimed the right to reuse those digital likenesses indefinitely- "for the rest of eternity," in some cases without clear terms or further pay.¹ The episode crystallized a fear that had been building across the entertainment industry: that a performer's face, voice, and creative work could be captured, stored, and regenerated by artificial intelligence long after the performer had left the set, or even died.

Since then, performers and their unions have pushed for new protections. SAG-AFTRA negotiated contracts requiring consent and disclosure before a "digital replica" of a performer can be created or used. Lawmakers have followed: Tennessee's ELVIS Act and new laws in California and New York restrict unauthorized voice and likeness clones,² while a proposed federal NO FAKES Act would create a right to seek remedies over nonconsensual digital replicas, extending decades after death.³ Meanwhile, some high-profile performers have moved in a different direction entirely, choosing to license their voices and likenesses proactively. Actors Matthew McConaughey and Michael Caine signed deals with the AI company ElevenLabs, which markets itself as a "performer-first" platform connecting brands with rights holders of famous voices.⁴ One actor who licensed his likeness to TikTok later found himself appearing in ads for insurance and brain teaser apps, none of which he had been compensated for, all within the terms of the agreement he had signed.⁵

A performer who signs away broad digital rights to get a role, or who licenses their voice before knowing exactly how it will be deployed, has technically agreed to all kinds of future uses. Whether they have genuinely consented is a harder question, especially given the emergence of pre-production licensing: AI companies can now approach performers to license their likeness before a project is conceived, let alone completed. A performer might be paid in advance for a project they will never see, playing a character they had no hand in shaping, in a work whose content they cannot predict.

Supporters of robust likeness protections argue that a person's face and voice are among the most intimate things they possess, and that to copy and deploy them without meaningful consent is a wrong independent of any legal framework. There is also a concern about the labor market: if a studio can scan a performer once and generate unlimited performances, working actors at every level may find themselves displaced not by other performers but by AI-generated versions of themselves or others. Posthumous use adds a further dimension. The dead cannot consent, and their images can be made to say or do things they never would have. However some argue that this cuts both ways, since digital tools have also allowed filmmakers to honor performers who died mid-production, and estates have sometimes welcomed the ability to extend a loved one's creative presence.

On the other side, some technologists and creators argue that likeness rights, if drawn too broadly, could chill legitimate forms of expression that have always been permitted: satire, commentary, biography, and imitation. They also point to real expansions of opportunity. AI tools can let performers reach audiences in languages they don't speak, complete projects that illness or age prevents them from finishing, and license their work in new ways that generate income on their own terms.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is it possible to consent in advance to an underspecified policy without knowing how the details will work out in practice?
2. To what extent is one's digital likeness an extension of oneself?

¹ [Movie extras worry they'll be replaced by AI. Hollywood is already doing body scans](#)

² [Tennessee Law Addresses Proliferation of Deepfakes](#)

³ [From ELVIS to AI, The Recording Academy Is Making Legislative Moves](#)

⁴ [Matthew McConaughey, Michael Caine license likenesses as generative AI debate deepens](#)

⁵ [AI & Deepfake Contracts: Legal Protection for Actors and Producers](#)

15: Playing It Safe

Alex has always admired his grandfather Frank. Growing up, Frank loved telling stories about hitchhiking across the country after high school, starting businesses that failed before eventually succeeding, and moving across the country with little more than a backpack and a few hundred dollars. Frank often says that “the best things in life happen because you take a risk.”

Alex's life has looked very different. As he prepares to graduate high school, Alex has turned down opportunities that many of his teachers encouraged him to pursue. He declined a semester abroad because of safety concerns over a geopolitical conflict, rejected a startup internship in favor of a more stable job, and chose to attend a college close to home rather than one several states away that offered more opportunities.

Frank cannot understand these decisions. He tells Alex that everyone faces uncertainty and that living well requires some level of risk. “If you're always waiting until something feels perfectly safe,” he says, “you'll never really live.” Frank worries that Alex and many of his peers have become so focused on avoiding harm that they miss opportunities to grow. Failure, embarrassment, and uncertainty, he argues, are often necessary parts of becoming resilient. Some psychologists have even suggested that overprotecting young people can leave them less prepared to handle setbacks later in life.

Alex disagrees. He thinks his grandfather underestimates the risks that exist or at least doesn't appreciate the nature of some of the risks. Alex also questions whether celebrating risk is always admirable. Many risks affect more than just the individual taking them. Starting an unstable business may place financial burdens on one's family. Traveling alone may worry loved ones. Choosing an uncertain career path can leave people unable to support children or ageing parents. From Alex's perspective, if someone can avoid unnecessary dangers, they should.

Frank sees another danger. He worries that prioritizing risk aversion above all else slowly changes how people understand a good life. People who avoid risk might also avoid difficult conversations, meaningful relationships, entrepreneurship, or careers that require sacrifice. Society itself may become less innovative if too many people choose security over exploration.

Alex wonders if that picture is too romantic. Many celebrated risk-takers also failed, suffered greatly, or harmed others through reckless decisions. Individuals and society benefit from stability, which is a reason to take less risks.

As they finish dinner, neither Alex nor Frank is convinced by the other. Both agree that some risks are worth taking and others are not, but they can't agree on how to determine when someone is reasonably assessing the risks they face.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. If someone can reasonably avoid unnecessary dangers, should they?
2. If taking a risk can lead to successful outcomes, does that mean that it is preferable to embrace those risks?
3. What is the moral status of “risk adversity”? What considerations should determine when we are obligated to take or avoid risk?



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